Just like every year for the past two decades, the Mahindra Excellence in Theatre Awards (META) has selected the top 10 plays from across India. The task was far from easy—META received almost 367 entries from 20 states across the country. Inclusivity and diversity have always been a keystone of the awards, so the submitted plays were in 32 Indian languages and dialects.

Admitting that it was an arduous task, Jay Shah, vice-president, head, cultural outreach, Mahindra & Mahindra Ltd, is all praise for the selection committee which included film and theatre actor Kuljeet Singh, film and television actor Divya Seth Shah, theatre and film casting director Dilip Shankar, theatre director Sankar Venkateswaran and director of puppet theatre Anurupa Roy. "They had the responsibility of selecting which plays demonstrate excellence in theatre. To see them work as a team, argue and vouch for the theatre they believe in, is truly heartening," he says.

The 10 plays selected have been nominated across 13 categories and will be staged in New Delhi from March 13 to 20, culminating in a glittering awards night. The plays include *Be-Loved: Theatre, Music, Queerness, and Ishq!* (Hindi/English); *Chandaa Bedni* (Hindi); *Bob Marley from Kodihalli, Dashanana Swapnasiddhi* and *Mattiah 22:39* (Kannada); *Jeevantey Maalakha* (Life's Angel) and *Kando Ningal Ente Kuttiye Kando?* (Have You Seen My Son?) (Malayalam), *Nihsango Ishwar* (Bangla & Sanskrit), *Portal Waiting* (English), and *Swang—Jas ki Tas* (Hindi and Bundeli).



For Jay, it has been a pleasant surprise to see three Kannada plays in the list. "We've had Kannada plays in the past as well but never so many in one year," he states. As always, he says, the intent of META is to promote the theatre fraternity and, particularly, regional theatre. "The entire idea has been to give place of pride to theatre as an art form and also the theatre communities and companies that operate at the margins by getting them centrestage in the national capital," he adds.

Venkateswaran seconds this opinion, "What excites me most is how this festival brings unheard stories to the forefront. It's not just about showcasing India's theatre landscape—it actively engages with the world, sparking conversations that transcend borders."

Director Sapan Saran, whose play *Be-Loved...* is a kaleidoscopic exploration of queer love through theatre, music, poetry and movement, has been nominated in six categories including Best Sound & Music, Best Costume, Best Play, Best Director, Best Script and Best Ensemble, says, "Festival shows are always special, primarily because of the audience they are able to attract." She adds that a national-level festival brings the community closer. "Theatre proponents get to watch each other's work. META has consistently done this for 20 years. It is a valuable contribution to the theatre ecosystem," she concludes. ■

–Deepali Dhingra





SINGALONG (clockwise from left) Thornetta Davis; Alvon Johnson; and Tia Carroll

OPENING THE FESTIVAL WILL BE ***ALVON JOHNSON****, A DYNAMIC PERFORMER WITH AN INFECTIOUS STAGE PRESENCE*

promises a soul-stirring experience. "Her honesty and restrained emotion create a compelling storytelling atmosphere," says Irani. "Her vocals will leave audiences with goosebumps."

Closing the festival is Tia Carroll, an award-winning artiste known for her raspy, powerful voice and high-energy performances. A staple of the West Coast blues scene, she effortlessly blends traditional blues with modern soul. "Tia's ability to fuse traditional blues with contemporary energy ensures the audience will leave feeling both joyful and deeply moved," notes Irani.

With its expansion, the festival is poised to become an exciting event on Mumbai's music calendar. "I see it evolving to be as big as our Jazz Festival, of course, with its own identity—something synonymous with blues music," says Irani. The NCPA Soulful Blues Festival should be an unmissable celebration of music, storytelling, and emotion. ■

–Nikhil Sardana